British rail historian Paul Atterbury states in his book *Along Lost Lines* (2007) that the idea of running special trains to carry passengers to and from ships and ferries dates back to the 1840s. Initially, they served ports on the Thames and the west coast of Scotland. By the 1880s, boat trains were running to ports and harbours all over Britain, serving ferries and ocean liners. The first railways in India were a version of this, but the idea of proper and 'branded' boat trains was based loosely on the lines of a Pullman. (Pullmans were luxury carriages developed by George Pullman that were independently staffed and offered a comfortable night's sleep. The American idea was taken to Britain in the 1870s.) This model was replicated in Bombay in the early 1920s with an elaborate port railway network put in place connected to the main lines of the GIP Railway and the BB&CI Railway.

> Mole station at Ballard Pier was a wharf that not just used to ferry cargo, but also troops and passengers from steamships (built 1910–12, extended 1914 and named after BPT's first chairman J.E. Ballard) to destinations in the north, including Karachi, now in Pakistan. The Punjab Limited train started off on 1 June, 1912 from Ballard Pier Mole station as a 'limited' service on certain days only to Peshawar. The train started originating and terminating at Bombay VT (now Mumbai CST) from 1914. It, however, took several days to get there. Today, it is called the Punjab Mail and takes 36 hours to cover the 1,929 km between Bombay and Ferozepore. [11 6]

The Frontier Mail

> Another boat train in the Bombay to Peshawar Frontier Mail made her maiden run from Colaba station on 1 September 1928, but during the winter months of September through December, it used to depart from Ballard Pier Mole station. The Frontier Mail had another reason for its introduction: the BB&CI Railway wanted to give its arch-rival, the GIP Railway, a run for its money. It was the idea of the BB&CI Railway's agent (now called the general manager) Sir Ernest Jackson to run these trains and compete with the GIP Railway. In fact, on the train's return from Peshawar, the Churchgate station building was lit to announce the safe arrival of passengers of the Frontier Mail, starting a new tradition of lighting of public buildings on railways. As the GIP's Punjab Limited took several days to get there, the Frontier Mail was faster and the transit time was reduced to a mere 72 hours. Today, the train runs out of Bombay Central and terminates at Amritsar, in the Punjab, and the name of the train has also been changed from Frontier Mail to Golden Temple Mail. It is interesting to note that when the train left Ballard Pier Mole station, it traversed over the tracks of the Bombay Port Trust Railway, Great Indian Peninsula Railway, and only then eventually crossed onto the metals of the Bombay Baroda and Central India Railway. Ballard Pier Mole station was an ideal hop -on point for the several British ladies and gentlemen arriving from England by steamer. It was also a pickup point for mail brought in from Europe by the P&O (formerly the Peninsular and Oriental Steam Navigation Company) mail steamer. [117]